

**Medford Public Schools
Medford, Massachusetts**

Committee of the Whole

April 30, 2015

The meeting was called to order at 7:00 p.m. in the Medford High School Library by Vice Chairperson John Falco Jr.

All rose to salute the Flag.

The following were present: School Committee members John Falco, Ann Marie Cugno, George Scarpelli, Robert Skerry Jr. and Paulette Van der Kloot. 5 present 2 absent.

Also present were Superintendent Belson, Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson, Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell, Pupil Services Director Kathy Medaglio, Clinical Supervisor Jeff Lappin, Director of Guidance Amelis Jensen, Health Services Supervisor Toni Vento, Head PE Teacher Rachel Perry, Principals D'Alleva, Edwards, Andrews, Kay, Guarino and Johnson. Assistant D.A. Alice Casey, City Councilor Breanna Lungo, School Physician Kristen Goodell, Police Chief Leo Sacco Jr, Officers James Ricciardi, Patrick O'Keefe and Rory Lockowitz, Team Medford Penny Bruce Funiciolo and Brook Hoyt, Overcoming Addiction Members Jacqueline Wynn, Gina Russell, Anthony Casella. Also Chris Murphy, Paul Toner and Irene HagiGeorgi.

Chairperson Falco stated that the purpose of the meeting was to review current programs and services in the Medford Public Schools and to consider next steps to address substance abuse.

Mr. Falco called the Superintendent to provide an overview of current programs and services.

The Superintendent made the following points:

- Issue of substance abuse is not new. School system has a long history of responding to these issues. There is no permanent fix. Rather this issue requires continuous attention, targeted programs and services, and diligent law enforcement.
- This is a national, state, regional and local issue.

- It is not the responsibility of any one entity in our community. It requires an integrated coherent effort and response from all agencies.
- Programs and services must do more than simply create awareness. We must build an awareness to generate attitude and behavioral change.
- We have policies in place. We will work to improve them.
- We have many programs and services and we will work to ensure they are effective.
- We need to re-energize our efforts to decrease risk factors and increase protective factors.
- Peer group development is a key approach.
- We must engage the adults to help with their families. (Homefront Initiative)
- We must stress the development of responsible decision-making skills.

Our goals tonight should be to inform on relevant information and data and to know what is already in place. Then we can better determine the specific area for intensified commitment.

The next speaker was Alice Casey representing Middlesex D.A. Marian Ryan. She emphasized that the DA's office is very active with local communities and school districts. The Middlesex Partnership for Youth and the Community Based Justice Program help to train school personnel and to keep them informed on street and court issues. The DA seeks to use special programs to provide alternatives to incarceration. The wide range of initiatives covers prevention, treatment, legislation, and prosecution. Her material highlighted both risk and protective factors by grade level. Overdose deaths have risen dramatically in the last year. She also highlighted the new ASAP program whose goal is to reduce underage alcohol and substance abuse. The program factors early intervention and remedial education. (see enclosed material)

School Dr. Kristin Goodell provided a perspective from pediatric practitioners. She talked about the increased anxiety levels among students. Today's culture promotes anxiety. Often adults and young people seek a medical solution like pills. This can lead to addiction. It can mean that extra meds are left available in homes for unprescribed use. There is a need for more self management skills.

School Committee member Paulette Van der Kloot spoke about the pressure on students today such as overtasking, getting into college, and genuine peer pressure. There is a need to promote responsible decision-making and to build up resilience. We also need to de-stress our student's environment and promote social and emotional well-being.

School Committee member George Scarpelli emphasized the need to ensure that our programs and services promote sustainability of a positive result. We need more after school options for our youth. We need a stronger recreational program. Member Skerry said that we need to have the right number of staff in place to meet our needs. He referenced the Peer Mediation Program.

Member Ann Marie Cugno stressed the need for a highly coordinated community effort. While we have many wonderful programs, we need to get the message out to youth and the community if we want participation and sustainability.

Vice Chairperson John Falco asked Chief Sacco about the DARE Program and staffing. He also emphasized the need for a coordinated effort with all agencies working together to get a positive result.

Medford Principal Jacob Edwards called for more staff at the middle school focused on social and emotional well being.

Art teacher Irene HagiGeorgi talked about fighting substance abuse with a global art initiative called the “Inside Out Project.” (see program description in folder)

Several members of the community group called “Overcoming Addiction” talked about working with recovering addicts who can help with real life examples.

Headmaster John Perella spoke about our new Chapter 222 programs that move away from “zero tolerance” to a relationship building model that helps to support positive behavioral change.

Director of Guidance Amelia Jensen said additional counseling support is necessary to provide sufficient individual attention.

Clinical Supervisor Jeff Lappin emphasized social and emotional programs to help our youth find support when they are vulnerable to substance abuse and depression. He said that they are working on a grant for Mental Health Assistance.

The Superintendent mentioned the Bloomberg Center initiatives are now being developed at Medford High School that will help with good decision-making and responsible citizenship.

There was discussion on how we could develop more peer groups like the current GSA that has had a very positive influential impact on students.

The School Committee agreed that the meeting was a positive session and that we need to follow up the good ideas presented.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Cugno the meeting adjourned at 9:28 p.m.

Respectfully submitted,

John Falco Jr.
Vice Chairperson